

Film/Animated Series – Look Book/Treatment



PhotosynthesisFilm.com

Based on the musical *Turnover: A New Leaf*

by David Quang Pham

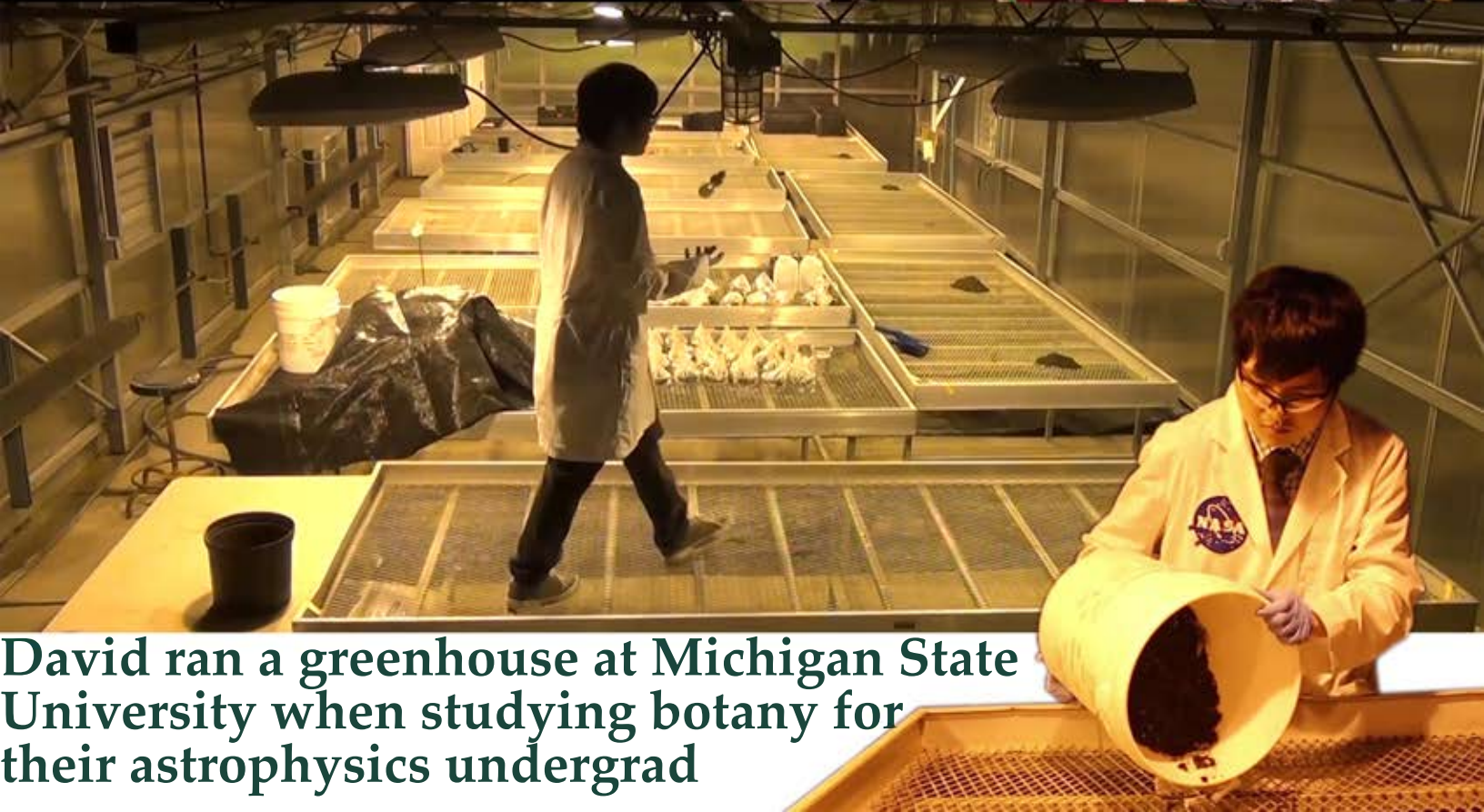


Contact:
616 818 5413
davidquangpham@outlook.com
11490 Oxnard St Apt 7, North Hollywood, CA 91606









David ran a greenhouse at Michigan State University when studying botany for their astrophysics undergrad



PREMISE

Photosynthesis is a plant-based animated musical comedy drama set in a world inhabited by photogenic plants. The feature follows a cilantro who owns a salon named Rau Ram ("cilantro" in Vietnamese) as she must earn her green card or else she gets uprooted and loses custody of her son Parsley. The series is a sequel to the feature and focuses more on the kids, Parsley and Pyrus, a good-natured herb and free-spirited pear, as they navigate Dirty City and create chaos with their naive antics and innocent friendship.

Photosynthesis is adapted from *Turnover: A New Leaf*. At the 2024 Philadelphia's New Musicals Festival, this musical won awards for Best Book and Best Director, and it was also nominated for Best Musical and Best Orchestrations. It also won the 2024 Great Performances Artist Fellowship Award. Queer Theatre Kalamazoo produced a world-premiere from May 16-18, 2025 and a concert on June 7, 2025.

With a mix of pop, rock, and Vietnamese folk, the many duets explore the friendships that queer liberation can spark, while the ensemble numbers explore the meaning of home. These story-driven songs and plant-inspired characters teach plant science.





SETTING

Photosynthesis is set in the garden nation of Woodwork. Inspired by Michigan and America, Woodwork has two peninsulas, shaped like a leaf above a tree trunk. The leaf peninsula has towns like Mt. Woodwork. The trunk has cities like Dirty City and the capitol. The story is mainly in Salontro salon or FigLeaf nightclub in Dirty City. Buildings are often shaped like pots or trees. Paddy Kingdom is inspired by Vietnam and Asia in general. Moss is grass to plants as grass is to humans.

- ❖ Woodwork (Plants born/naturalized here have green cards/hands)



❖ Dirty City

- ❖ Cantaloupe Outlets
- ❖ FigLeaf Nightclub – owner: Malus Crabapple
- ❖ Rootimentary School
- ❖ Salontro – Rau and Parsley’s home; landlord: Malus
- ❖ Dirtharmonic Performance Hall
- ❖ City Hall





- ✿ Woody Holly (based on Hollywood)
 - ✿ Herbivore Studios
 - ✿ The Sunshine Garden
 - ✿ Mt. Woodwork
 - ✿ Pyrus's House ✿ Woodwork National Park
 - ✿ Cherry Tree, Woodwork Capitol
 - ✿ The Green House ✿ Department of Garden Security Headquarters

- ✿ Paddy Kingdom (Plants born/naturalized here have red cards/hands)

- ✿ Adansonia (based on Africa)

- ✿ Banyan (based on India)

- ✿ Bereza Federation (based on Russia and Eastern Europe)

- ✿ Canguro (based on Oceania)

- ✿ Floresta (based on South America)

- ✿ Snow Meadows (based on Antarctica)

- ✿ Tulip (based on Europe)



CHARACTERS

In addition to the principal characters, *Photosynthesis* has an androgynous supporting cast of families, children, and generic plants who are there to be introduced in each episode for the audience to learn from. These characters can be featured, developed, and/or done away with as necessary.



The Rams

RAU RAM, 36, is the devoted mother of Parsley and crafty owner of Silantro salon which neighbors FigLeaf nightclub. This transplant cilantro grew up in Paddy Kingdom before lucking out in the Green Card Lottery, leading to her emigration to the nation of Woodwork. She made herself at home in Dirty City as it was dirt cheap, assuming it can only get cleaner from here. Despite many locals viewing her as an invasive species, her resilience helped shape her salon as Woodwork's finest and her son as an integral member of the garden. She hopes her family will be welcomed everywhere on Woodwork. However, she often sees her neighbor Malus as unnatural and Malus's nibbling Pyrus as a bad influence on Parsley and a barrier to earning her green card.

PARSLEY RAM, 11, is a fun-loving and optimistic herb whose only friend has been his overprotective mom, Rau Ram. He helps out his Vietnamese immigrant mom around Salantro – Dirty City's finest salon – and teaches square roots at Rootimentary summer school. Unlike his mother, he looks up to their neighbor Malus. Their incoming nibbling Pyrus soon comes in and changes all their lives. Parsley is the only plant who does not look down on Pyrus. Pyrus Crabapple, whose family lived in Woodwork for generations, pushes Parsley to turn a new leaf.



The Crabapples

MALUS CRABAPPLE, 40s, is Pyrus's unty and down-to-Earth owner of FigLeaf nightclub which neighbors Salontro salon. They were a Paddy War special agent who was a mentee of Agent Minneola Orange. So, Rau Ram, the Vietnamese immigrant salon owner, and they have a tumultuous yet symbiotic business relationship. Rau's behavior is invasive to them while their queerness is unnatural to Rau. Despite this, Malus is a well-intentioned apple, who enjoys Parsley's (Rau's son) company. Their sister asks them to raise their child, Pyrus, better than she could. And for their sister's sake, they try hard to get Pyrus to behave themselves this summer. However, their sister's trust does not stop Malus from revisiting their parents' abandonment. They must confront their tragic past by bettering their nibbling's present experience in Dirty City.

PYRUS CRABAPPLE, 13, is a free-spirited pear whose acne leads to bullying alongside the many convoluted troublemaking responses for their foes. They often retreat into the comforts of their pet bee Bombus, or their jazz band The Woodwinds. After nearly getting expelled out of Terra Hill Conservatory and soiling the Crabapple family name, their mother sends them out to unty Malus in Dirty City. They find Malus's nightclub business to be lonesome. Little does Pyrus know that they would find a fruitful friend in the little herb next door. Parsley Ram, the son of a Vietnamese immigrant salon owner, helps Pyrus turn a new leaf.

BOMBUS BUMBLE B is the loving and innovative pet of Pyrus, who took this stray bee in. They are quite an intellectual, spending their days solving mazes and crafting buzzwords in word games. They talk with their buzzes, emote with their eyes, and sting by writing insults in honey ink. To the other bees, their buzzing is unintelligible. Bombus has a similar experience to countless children of immigrants who cannot speak their mother tongue.

Other Residents of Dirty City, Woodwork

MAYOR CANNA BLOMQUIST, 50s, is the rotten and fourth wall-breaking mayor of Dirty City. They are Secretary of Garden Security Rhizo Blomquist's twin sibling.

NURSE BIRCH, 50s, is Rootimentary School's nurse.

ALTON DANDY, 40s, is a real estate mogul who founded All Dandy Properties. They are the feature's secondary antagonist.

SALIX WILLOW, 40s, is a therapist from Gongyuan who cannot help but weep. They are Rau's business rival in the wellness industry.



Woodwork Government

SECRETARY RHIZO BLOMQUIST, 50s, is the head of the Soil and Plant Protection (SAPP) Agency as the Secretary of Garden Security and Mayor Canna's twin sibling who is always better than Canna. They are the root of suffering for many transplants while being a child of one. They are the feature's main antagonist.

PRESIDENT PUMPKIN EATER, 50s, is the President of Woodwork. They are the epitome of a cheater. They live in the Green House.

SAPP AGENTS / OFFICERS, are Woodworkan immigration officers and agents who uproot transplants.

Residents of Mt. Woodwork, Woodwork

THUJA CARPENTER, 40s, is the pine tree park ranger with an eye patch who comes from a holiday freak show family.

MUSA PISANG, 14, is a music student who goes bananas at Terra Hill Conservatory and is the flute player in Pyrus's band The Woodwinds.

RHUBARB AVAZ, 30s, is the Persian Rubab-playing music teacher at Terra Hill Conservatory and Pyrus's sworn enemy due to her insistence on practicing.

Residents in The Sunshine Garden, Woodwork

KEY LIME, 8, is a kid who cannot swim unless it is in sparkling water.

MUSAMI CITRUS, 8, is Key's friend who mentors them on how to swim.

Other Plant Characters

ACHIRA BLOMQUIST, 80s, is a transplant rights activist and the first transplant to be elected to public office, as a senator of San Clay. She is the mother of Canna and Rhizo.

DJ CAULIFLOWER, 20s, is the hip-hop and coolest Cruciferous on tour.

AGENT MINNEOLA ORANGE, 30s, is a deceased agent during the Paddy War.

LAMI MENTHA, 30s, is a minty superstar and businessowner.

ANANAS PINEAPPLE, 40s, is a callous piney entrepreneur whose family founded Y n' Pizza chain. They tour around in their food truck.



SUNFLOWER, 60s, is a pop rock folk singer who leads The Beetroots, where the guitarist, bassist, and drummer are literal beets.

WOAD, 60s, is a spiritual healer of sorts.

Fresh Ground Pepper

PAPA VER

ABEL ESCULENTUS

HELIA

ALLI SHALLOT

JAZZ NOCTURNAL

SCALLI FISTU

OCI TULASEE

TOM SOLAN

KUDZU LOBATA

PIPER BELL

Bugs

BEES, a plant's dog or cat.

BEETLES, musical birds who can chirp melodies to the plants.

HORNET, a plant's illegal pet tiger.

FLEAS, hopping pets often sold at the flea market.



THEMES

Photosynthesis presents the connections that science and plant biology have with society and family. With synthesizing photographs, the series is rooted in the multiple meanings of roots from family roots to rooting for one another in the community to identifying root causes of problems and developing solutions to address them.

Why the pear and herb? For Vietnamese dishes, cilantro is a cultural garnish. And pear trees filled David Quang Pham's childhood home in the city of Wyomring, Michigan. The green card is rooted from their relationship with their **immigrant** parents as an American-born son and their family's deep care for green nature.

The series message is that it is okay for gardens to have biodiversity and that plants can live in peace and harmony if we tend to what they need if certain conditions are hard for them to adapt to. The green card element symbolizes **adaptation** and **acceptance**. Green cards, to plants and humans, are not easy to obtain unless you are born into the garden's specific soil. Parsley is a green card holder of UVS, but Rau is not.

With the show being inspired by David Quang Pham's musical theatre background, there are **music lessons** layered within. With anything featuring Pyrus's archnemesis music teacher Rhubarb, the series explores their relationship, showing how the lines between tough coaching and abusive behavior can become blurred. With Mayor Canna Blomquist, we can learn the **nature of power** and the influence that local governments have on our lives.

SELECT SONGS (from *Turnover: A New Leaf*)

Links in **Blue**

["Move the Plot Forward"](#)

["A Natural"](#)

["Amount to Anything"](#)

["Photosynthesis"](#)

["Crop Top"](#)

["Soiled \(The Family Name\)"](#)

["Fertile"](#)

["Dirt on You"](#)

["Turnover \(A New Leaf\)"](#)



Photosynthesis Movie

Genre: Rites of Passage (with elements of Buddy Love)

Opening Image: A lonely photo and immigration case file of Rau Ram, an expectant mother on her way to Dirty City, Woodwork.

Theme Stated: "A green card ain't green on the other side." - Malus Crabapple

Rau believes a green card would grant her a place in the nation's soil. It can be as lonesome as not having one. Her photos are just her and her son now, but as they better the community, she will learn what it means to belong.

Set-Up: Rau Ram, a cilantro, emigrates to Dirty City. She could not find a home for her salon business. However, Malus, a nightclub owner and landlord, offers her their spare plot of land. The difference between them is night and day for the nightclub owner and salon owner. She soon has a son named Parsley.

Catalyst: After a dozen years, Rau's green card application is finally up for review. It comes at a time when more "invasive species" are forced out of Woodwork. She's only able to stay in this garden because her son is a natural born citizen. With a green card, she can legally own Salontro and get it off Malus's hand.

Debate: Pyrus, a pear suspended from their conservatory, visits town and stays with their unty Malus. They befriend the well-behave Parsley. Rau sees Pyrus as a bad influence.

Break into Two: Rau could never save up when paying rent. However, Malus strikes a deal that they won't charge them if Parsley is Pyrus's school tutor.

B Story: Rau needs all hands on deck to save up to purchase Salontro, while Parsley plays hooky with Pyrus and does everything they can to hide their adventures.

Fun and Games: Overtime, Rau saves enough to purchase Salontro. Parsley seems queer and weird to Rau. Malus asks Rau to come to their summer solstice retreat. Parsley opens up and asks to hang out with Pyrus as friends in Cantaloupe Outlets. Rhizo Blomquist offers Rau her green card if she gives them her book containing other transplants' addresses. She accepts. She cannot hold this news any longer and goes to see Parsley. She finds Parsley and Pyrus wearing crop tops which makes her lash out.

Midpoint: Rau does this summer solstice retreat to get on Malus's good side in buying Salontro. While on the retreat with Malus, she learns about Malus being kicked out by



their parents for being queer and how they found a home in FigLeaf and their experience with immigrants. Malus gifts the deed to Salontro at no charge.

Bad Guys Close In: Parsley sneaks out. Pyrus has an unlawful rave at FigLeaf that leads to Parsley's hospitalization and their arrest. Dirty City shuts down FigLeaf. Hoping to keep the family integrity, Rau decides not to stick up for Malus and blames their community for "misleading" her son.

All is Lost: Rau keeps Salontro salon, but her son Parsley won't speak to her. She loses her regulars and lives on her savings.

Dark Night of the Soul: Parsley runs away with Pyrus to their hometown of Mt. Woodwork. No one will help even a Woodwork citizen find her son. Rau is alone ("A green card ain't green on the other side").

Breaking into Three: On a calendar, Rau looks at past photos of her and Parsley. It's been a photo of her alone these past many days. She finds the photobooth photo of Parsley and Pyrus. It's the happiest Parsley has ever been.

Finale: In a city auction, Rau almost wins FigLeaf's domain, but All Dandy Properties outbids. Rau squats on the premises, halting the demolition. She gains public support but is alone in a water-hunger strike. Secretary of Garden Security Rhizo and their Transplant Service Officers revoke Rau's green card. Seeing the news, Parsley worries. He returns, making Rau leave her post. FigLeaf gets bulldozed. Rhizo chases Rau into Salontro, but the kids trap Rhizo in a tanning bed. Changed by its magic, Rhizo threatens the developers with legal action for exploitations of transplants. Rau knows she'll have to wait another dozen years for her green card to be reconsidered. For now, she helps rebuild FigLeaf and welcomes Pyrus to the Salontro family.

Final Image: A group photo of Rau surrounded by those who love her.



TYPICAL EPISODE

The objective of each episode is to a) introduce new plant characters; b) connect biodiversity with themes of family; c) explore Dirty City and the state of Woodwork; and d) take photos. The characters can take selfies and photos that will be planted into the end credits of each episode. The photos may also be significant in feature episodes. Every time the characters take a photo, they sing the photosynthesis jingle: “Photosynthesis, photosynthesis, photo!” There will often be at least a song written by David Quang Pham or another songwriter in each episode.

Photosynthesis

(from *Turnover: A New Leaf* by David Quang Pham)

Sugar Rush! (♩ = 144)

PARSLEY: $B\flat$ Gm^7 $E\flat$ F^7 $E\flat$ $B\flat$ F $B\flat$ Gm^7 $E\flat$ F^7

C 6 H_2 12 O_6 plus 6 H_2O 6 carbon 12 hydrogen 6

PYRUS:

Sugar, glucose, sugar, and starch. Your cellulose.

$E\flat$ $B\flat$ F $B\flat$ Gm $E\flat$ **GARDEN:** $B\flat$

oxy-gen... plus 6 oxy-gen molecules. Photo-synthesis. Photo-synthesis. Photo!

GARDEN:

Your cellulose. This is photosynthesis. Photo-synthesis. Photo!

Photo snaps.

Pyrus often initiates the misadventures through their own wrongdoing while Parsley naively goes along with their best friend. The end of each episode usually shows that it is never too late to do the right thing, even if you have done wrong before. Like many animated series, these kinds of situations lead to a fun or comedic outcome.

There will be episodes on Pyrus and Malus’s relationship or Bombus’s or Parsley and his mom Rau’s relationship. In an episode titled “Behave for a Bee Hive,” Parsley walks by a petting zoo and asks Rau for a pet bee, like Pyrus’s Bombus. Rau accidentally gifts Parsley a hornet, which terrorizes the town. Other episodes will center Rau’s immigrant struggles beyond the difficulties of earning a green card, from cultural clashes and the pressure to live up to expectations.

With any episode that features Rhubarb, Pyrus’s unhinged music teacher and archnemesis, there are music theory lessons planted throughout. The episodes that feature Mayor Canna Blomquist have them get their comeuppance mixed with them being able to slip through scandals.



SERIES DEVELOPMENT

At first, Pyrus has very few friends and lacks body confidence. So, they often resort to bullying to get their way. It gets so out of hand that their parents push Pyrus out of Mt. Woodwork and into unty Malus's care in Dirty City. Little did they know that they would befriend the neighboring immigrant salon owner's son named Parsley there.

Parsley has little time for friends due to spending much of it helping their mom around the Salontro business. He is also treated differently from his classmates due to being the son of a non-green card holder. There is immense pressure for him to live up to family expectations, so Parsley often yearns for adventures away from it. It would make sense for him to connect with the openly weird and queer Pyrus.

Pyrus and Parsley continuously learn that they need each other, Pyrus for adventure and Parsley for moderation. Pyrus grows more well-intentioned and morally ambiguous in their decisions that often turn out bad, like partying or pranking. Meanwhile, Pyrus grows more experimental and unrestrained in their life, often tied down to how they will be publicly perceived as a member of the immigrant community.

Photos taken from each episode will be compiled and displayed for features, used as teachable moments and to chart the evolution of relationships.

Rau eventually earns their green card, but it comes after developing the communal trait of hers. Malus's FigLeaf Nightclub eventually gets shut down due to Pyrus and Parsley. Malus will mentally get in shape when the time comes, so they are able to reflect on their time. There will be development for other adult characters such as the rotten Mayor Canna Blomquist, the insane music teacher Rhubarb Avaz, and the weeping therapist Salix Willow.



EPISODES

BEHAVE FOR A BEE HIVE

Walking by the petting zoo, Parsley eyes a bee and wants one like Pyrus. Rau jokes if Parsley gets all As this semester they will get a pet bee. Parsley achieves that. Rau keeps her promise, partially. She accidentally gets a hornet from the black bean market, which unleashes terror upon the town. Pyrus calls in Bombus to take down this worthy foe.

BEFRIENDING THE BEHEMOTH (Related Episode)

FIRST PLANT

Cosmonaut Thaliana Rock-Cress and astronaut Dracaena Maize, the first two plants in space, visit Parsley's school, inspiring him to want to go to the Moon.

HAY DAY

MINT CONDITION

The pristine superstar business owner, Lami Mentha, is in town for a film shoot. They pay a visit to the world-class Salontro, which ends up disastrous when Lami gets an allergic reaction from a product. Will Salontro survive this PR nightmare?

PINEAPPLE PIZZA

Parsley visits Pyrus in Woodwork National Park for their first camping trip together. When a pineapple visits the park with their pizza truck, mysterious incidents occur all about. Should pineapples be allowed to make pizza, even if they lead to the apocalypse?

ROOT WORD

SQUARE ROOT

VOLTI SUBITO (TURN QUICKLY)

Rhubarb Avaz - Pyrus's music teacher and archnemesis - is in town as the seasoned conductor for the Dirtharmonic Orchestra. Malus believes Pyrus can get in her good graces if they apprentice her. Will Pyrus grace the harmony or stand out in the melody?

WEEPING WILLOW

Rau cannot burn out. She drinks enough water each day after all. But in comes the only person who can burn her out: a therapist. Salix Willow, a native from Paddy Kingdom, keeps coming into Salontro and striking up conversations that make Rau tremble, revisiting her past in Paddy Kingdom.



SCIENCE EDUCATION IS IMPORTANT

The knowledge of science is important because it cultivates critical thinking skills by encouraging curiosity, questioning, and evidence-based analysis, allowing individuals to better understand the world around them, make informed decisions, and solve problems through a methodical approach. It also fosters creativity and adaptability to change. Think critically and approach challenges with a scientific mindset.

PLANTS ARE IN

People are often drawn to plants as they can significantly improve mental well-being by reducing stress, boosting mood, and enhancing creativity, while also providing a sense of responsibility through nurturing and caring for a living thing; additionally, plants contribute to cleaner air quality and can aesthetically enhance a space.

FABLES ARE IN

People are drawn to fables because they offer easily accessible life lessons and moral messages, often conveyed through engaging stories featuring anthropomorphic characters, making them a simple and relatable way to learn about important values and behaviors.